Our home, our minhag

10 minutes together | Optional 5-10 minutes deeper | K-8

נר איש וביתו

A light for a person and their household.

Shabbat 21b | Short excerpt; original English translation.

READ TOGETHER | 3 MIN

Chanukah brings the mitzvah into the home. Rabbi Yosef Karo's Shulchan Aruch describes one set of lights that increases each night for the household. Rabbi Moshe Isserles, the Rema, records the Ashkenazic practice of individual household members lighting. Sephardic families generally follow the household practice; many Ashkenazic families have several members light. Each family follows its minhag. Different practices can express a shared love of the same mitzvah.

ONE HALACHA TO TAKE HOME | 1 MIN

Women and men are obligated in Chanukah lighting. A woman can light for the household. Children learn to participate according to their family's custom and with adult supervision. Helping prepare or singing together also gives children a meaningful role.

TALK & TRY | 4 MIN

Ask a partner: Who lit when you were little? Where did you gather? Which song do you remember? If no one remembers, choose a song or learning routine your family can begin now.

Younger learners: Name one way you can help your family celebrate.
Older learners: How can we explain another family's minhag respectfully, even when it differs from ours?

TELL IT BACK | 2 MIN

1. Are women obligated in Chanukah lighting? 2. Do all Jewish families follow exactly the same household-lighting practice?

GO DEEPER | OPTIONAL 5-10 MIN

Compare Shulchan Aruch and Rema, O.C. 671:2. The Rema also discusses keeping people's lights in distinct places. Why does being able to recognize each set matter?

Sources: Shabbat 21b; Household customs: Shulchan Aruch and Rema, O.C. 671:2; Women: Shulchan Aruch, O.C. 675:3.

Turn over for the source texts. Learn with a parent, sibling, grandparent, or another partner. Answer aloud; adults may read. Catch up anytime. Record actual learning minutes after Shabbat; each child submits separately.

Inside the sources

Original Hebrew / Aramaic with original English translations. Excerpts are labeled; ... marks omissions. Read one passage together or explore all of them.

1. Shabbat 21b | A household mitzvah

Selected passage

ת"ר מצות חנוכה נר איש וביתו והמהדרין נר לכל אחד ואחד

The Sages taught: The Chanukah mitzvah is a lamp for a person and their household. Those who beautify the mitzvah have a lamp for each person.

2. Shulchan Aruch, O.C. 671:2 | Household lighting

Selected passage

כמה נרות מדליק? בלילה הראשון מדליק אחד, מכאן ואילך מוסיף והולך אחד בכל לילה, עד שבליל אחרון יהיו שמונה. ואפילו אם רבים בני הבית לא ידליקו יותר.

How many lamps does one light? On the first night, one; afterward, one adds a lamp each night, until there are eight on the last night. Even if there are many household members, they do not light more.

3. Rema on O.C. 671:2 | Individual lighting

Parenthetical source citations omitted

ויש אומרים דכל אחד מבני הבית ידליק ... וכן המנהג פשוט. ויזהרו לתן כל אחד ואחד נרותיו במקום מיוחד כדי שיהא היכר כמה נרות מדליקין

Some say that each household member should light ... and this is the widespread custom. Each person should be careful to put their lamps in a distinct place, so that the number being lit can be recognized.

4. Shulchan Aruch, O.C. 675:3; Magen Avraham 675:4

Opening words of the ruling and opening explanation

אשה מדלקת נר חנוכה שאף היא חייבת בה

מגן אברהם: פי' בעד כל בני הבית

A woman lights the Chanukah lamp, for she too is obligated in it. Magen Avraham explains: This means on behalf of all the household members.

DISCUSS THE SOURCES

The first two rulings describe different ways to beautify the same mitzvah. Explain why distinct places help identify the number of lights.

Read originals online: Source 1 | Source 2 | Source 3 | Source 4. Hebrew transcribed from the cited editions; vowel marks omitted and punctuation adjusted for readability.